

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Religion and Morality - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II, Section B | 32 diagnostics, 11 solved PYQs and 6 original Mains models

LEARNING PATH



Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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Religion and Morality - Solved Practice Workbook

Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · Topic 08 A standalone practice document. It is designed to be worked without the learning session open beside it, and it repeats no teaching prose.

How to use this workbook

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** by a randomised, length-balanced assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and each of the four positions carries exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; **the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

What is inside

Part	Content	Count
1	Core diagnostic MCQs	24
2	Remedial diagnostic MCQs	8
-	Question-specific option explanations	128
-	Unique examiner traps	32
3	Verified previous-year questions, fully solved	11
4	Original solved Mains models (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20)	6
5	Question-shaped timed-paper compression plan	11 rows

Marking and timing conventions

- Word bands: 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words.
- Every model answer follows **claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification**.
- Every model answer closes with a decided verdict, and the twenty-mark models additionally name the **defeater** that would change that verdict.
- **Standing penalties in this clause:** merging the four dependence relations; inferring logical dependence from sociological influence; giving only one horn of the Euthyphro; identifying *dharma* with universal morality; answering the violence stem with a list of conflicts; silently regularising the 2018 printed word "immorality"; and using the sentence commonly paraphrased as "without God everything is permitted" as a verified quotation from Dostoevsky.

Terminology rule

English-first throughout. The English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit, Pali, Greek, German or Latin term follows in parentheses.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** by a randomised, length-balanced assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and each of the four positions carries exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

MCQ 1. Which relation is being asserted?

A candidate writes that "morality depends on religion". Which statement expresses the **metaphysical grounding** version of that claim rather than one of the other three?

- A. Religious communities transmit moral habits more effectively than isolated individuals form them, so moral formation is a communal achievement.
- B. Belief that conduct is finally judged raises compliance in exactly those cases where detection by other people is improbable or impossible.
- C. The validity of a moral obligation is constituted by a religious fact, such as the command of God, so that removing the fact removes the obligation itself.
- D. Moral reformers have historically drawn their vocabulary of dignity, justice and conscience from the religious traditions they were criticising.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is a claim about moral formation and socialisation, which belongs to religion's *influence* on conduct and settles nothing about what makes an obligation valid.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the **sanction and accountability** relation - what connects conduct to consequence - and it is compatible with obligation being grounded entirely elsewhere.
- **C:** Correct: grounding asks what *constitutes* validity, and the constitution test is exactly the one stated - remove the religious fact and the obligation goes with it.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is a genealogical or historical point about vocabulary, and where a concept came from is a different question from what now makes it binding.

Examiner trap 1: A script that never says which of the four relations it is discussing cannot be graded above the average band, however much doctrine it contains; name the relation in the opening sentence and hold to it.

MCQ 2. What behavioural evidence can and cannot establish

Suppose it is well attested that religious participation correlates with higher charitable giving. What follows philosophically?

- A. Divine command theory survives the Euthyphro dilemma, because a theory with such consequences cannot be the arbitrary doctrine its critics allege.
- B. Those who do not participate in religious practice cannot know that charity is morally required of them or of anyone else.
- C. Charitable giving is obligatory only in so far as it is commanded, since the correlation reveals the true source of the obligation.
- D. Religion may causally influence conduct, but neither logical dependence nor any conclusion about moral truth follows from the correlation.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the Euthyphro is a conceptual objection to a theory of grounding, and no volume of behavioural evidence bears on whether a command constitutes obligation.
- **B:** Incorrect: this confuses causal influence with epistemic access, and it is refuted by the ordinary fact that non-participants make and defend the same moral judgement.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is precisely the inference the correlation cannot support, since a cause of compliance is not a constituent of obligation.
- **D:** Correct: correlation establishes at most a contingent influence, and may itself require controls for community, selection and orientation before even that is secure.

Examiner trap 2: The correlation trap is the commonest single failure in this clause because the evidence really is good; concede the influence generously and then state, in the same sentence, the inference it cannot support.

MCQ 3. How divine command theory should be stated

Which formulation states the thesis that the Euthyphro dilemma is actually aimed at?

- A. The word "wrong" simply means "forbidden by God", so an atheist who calls an act wrong is not using the term in the primary sense it bears.
- B. Moral obligation is constituted by God's command, so that being commanded is what the obligatoriness of an act consists in.
- C. Belief in a commanding God is what in practice moves most people to act morally when acting morally is costly to them.
- D. Religion supplies moral education, so that without religious teaching most people would never acquire the concepts morality requires.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the **semantic** version, the strongest and least defensible reading, and almost no defender of the theory holds it; refuting it proves very little.
- **B:** Correct: the metaphysical version is the real thesis - command is constitutive of obligation, not evidential, motivational or reinforcing - and it is the version the dilemma targets.
- **C:** Incorrect: this is the **motivational** version; it may well be true of many agents and it says nothing about what makes an act obligatory.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is a claim about moral pedagogy, and a theory of moral education cannot be attacked by a dilemma about the constitution of obligation.

Examiner trap 3: Attacking the semantic version and announcing that divine command theory has been refuted is a straw-man move an examiner will see immediately; aim at the constitutive claim.

MCQ 4. The presupposition Kant denies

Divine command theory rests on three presuppositions. Which one does the Kantian reject while leaving the other two untouched?

- A. That authority as such can generate moral reasons, so that a command issued by a legitimate superior binds the agent by itself.
- B. That God exists as a supreme personal being capable of issuing commands that apply universally to every rational agent whatever.
- C. That divine commands are knowable, so that fallible human agents can reliably identify what has in fact been commanded of them in a given case.
- D. That divine knowledge and goodness secure the rightness of the content commanded, so that the commands will never be perverse.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: Kant's objection is that a law given by another will is heteronomous, so authority as such cannot generate a genuinely moral reason however legitimate the authority is.
- **B:** Incorrect: existence is contested by the atheist, not by the Kantian as a Kantian; Kant retains God as a practical postulate rather than denying the being.
- **C:** Incorrect: the knowability worry is an epistemic objection pressed hardest in the religious-violence module, and it is not the distinctively Kantian complaint.
- **D:** Incorrect: the content-guarantee is challenged by the Euthyphro's arbitrariness horn, which is a different objection from the autonomy objection at issue here.

Examiner trap 4: Candidates routinely present Kant as an atheistic critic; the sharper and more accurate presentation is that Kant grants the theist his God and still denies that a command can ground obligation.

MCQ 5. The dilemma in both horns

Which pair correctly states the two horns of the Euthyphro dilemma and the cost of each?

- A. Either God exists and morality is objective, or God does not exist and morality is a human convention with no genuine claim on anyone at all.
- B. Either goodness is constituted by the command, which makes morality arbitrary, or the command follows goodness, which makes goodness independent.
- C. Either revelation discloses moral truth reliably, or moral truth is inaccessible, in which case no one can be blamed for moral failure at all.
- D. Either God is omnipotent and evil is unreal, or evil is real and God's power over the created order must be significantly limited.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the objectivity-versus-conventionalism debate, not the Euthyphro, which is entirely available to a theist and does not turn on God's existence.
- **B:** Correct: this is the dilemma as Plato states it at *Euthyphro* 10a, with the arbitrariness cost on the first horn and the independence cost on the second.
- **C:** Incorrect: this concerns epistemic access to moral truth and belongs to the reason-and-revelation clause rather than to the constitution of obligation.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is the problem of evil, which shares Plato's dialogical form in some presentations but has an entirely different target.

Examiner trap 5: A script that gives one horn has given half a dilemma, which is not a dilemma at all; the second horn is what an examiner scans for to test whether the structure is understood.

MCQ 6. The consequence that strengthens the first horn

Beyond arbitrariness, what further damage does the first horn of the Euthyphro do to the theist's own position?

- A. It shows that God could not have created a world containing genuinely free agents capable of moral responsibility.
- B. It shows that revelation must be superfluous, since a command that constitutes goodness could never be misunderstood by its recipients.
- C. It shows that moral knowledge would have to be innate, since no experience could disclose what a bare act of will has instituted.
- D. It empties the affirmation of divine goodness, since the claim that God is good collapses into the tautology that God commands what God commands.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: free will and moral responsibility are the terrain of the problem of evil and of theological determinism, not a consequence of the arbitrariness horn.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing in the horn implies that commands are self-interpreting; misidentification of the divine will is a separate and independently pressed objection.
- **C:** Incorrect: innateness is a thesis in moral epistemology and does not follow from a claim about what constitutes goodness.
- **D:** Correct: if goodness just is what God commands, the central theistic affirmation of divine goodness becomes vacuous, so the horn threatens theology as well as ethics.

Examiner trap 6: Stopping at arbitrariness is what separates the average band from the good band here; the vacuity consequence is short to state and it is the point examiners reward.

MCQ 7. What Adams actually changed

What is Robert Merrihew Adams's central modification of divine command theory?

- A. Obligation is grounded in the commands of an essentially loving God, while goodness is grounded in resemblance to the divine nature.
- B. Moral obligation is wholly reducible to the anticipation of divine reward and the fear of divine punishment in a life after death.
- C. Moral goodness is whatever a recognised religious authority declares it to be, provided the authority is legitimately constituted within its tradition.
- D. Divine commands are unnecessary to ethics, because the consequences of an action are the only thing that determines whether it ought to be done.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the split is the move - obligation from command, goodness from resemblance to nature - and it is what blocks the arbitrariness horn without abandoning the theory.
- **B:** Incorrect: this reduces the theory to a prudential sanction account, which is the version Kant's heteronomy objection destroys and which Adams is not defending.
- **C:** Incorrect: this substitutes ecclesiastical or institutional authority for the divine nature and reintroduces exactly the arbitrariness the modification exists to prevent.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is a consequentialist thesis, and Adams's theory is a form of divine command theory rather than a rejection of one.

Examiner trap 7: Writing "Adams says God is loving so the problem disappears" earns nothing; the mark is for the *split* between the ground of obligation and the ground of goodness.

MCQ 8. The reply that blocks the regress

Which position holds that God is the supreme standard of goodness rather than a being who conforms to an external standard, on the model of the standard metre bar?

- A. Linda Zagzebski's divine motivation theory, which grounds moral value in God's motivational states rather than in God's legislative acts.
- B. Immanuel Kant's doctrine of the practical postulates, which secures the coherence of the moral outlook without grounding the moral law in God.
- C. William Alston's standard reply, which denies that there must be a further standard the divine nature has to match in order to be good.
- D. The natural-law tradition, which holds that basic human goods are disclosed by inclination and directed to their ends by practical reason.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Zagzebski relocates the ground from commands to motives, which converts the theory into a virtue ethics but does not deploy the standard-metre analogy.
- **B:** Incorrect: the postulates concern what practical reason must presuppose, and Kant's whole point is that God is not the source of the moral law at all.
- **C:** Correct: Alston's reply denies the assumed regress by treating God as the standard itself, so the demand for a further standard misconstrues what a standard is.
- **D:** Incorrect: natural law grounds the order in divine reason and gives reason the access, but it does not answer the regress by an appeal to a paradigm standard.

Examiner trap 8: The standard-metre analogy is regularly misattributed to Adams; keeping Adams's split and Alston's standard distinct is a cheap and visible precision gain.

MCQ 9. What the modified theory concedes

What is the strongest residual objection to modified divine command theory?

- A. Describing the divine nature as loving deploys a moral concept whose content we must already grasp independently of the theory itself.
- B. It denies that God can be loving, and therefore contradicts the central affirmation that every theistic tradition makes about the divine character.
- C. It establishes that all moral values are ultimately subjective, since a nature is a psychological rather than a normative kind of thing.
- D. It makes moral obligation impossible for anyone who lacks access to a revealed text in which the relevant commands are recorded and transmitted.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the residue - non-arbitrariness is secured at the cost of conceding conceptual independence to goodness, which is what the second horn asserts.
- **B:** Incorrect: the theory affirms rather than denies divine love; the objection is about the *concept* of love, not about whether the attribute is possessed.
- **C:** Incorrect: nothing in the objection entails subjectivism, and the theory is a form of moral realism about both goodness and obligation.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is the access objection, which is pressed against command theories generally and is not the distinctive residue of the modification.

Examiner trap 9: Presenting the modified theory as a clean victory over the Euthyphro reads as advocacy; the evaluative verdict is *relocation*, not refutation, and it must be stated as such.

MCQ 10. The fork that decides moral worth

On Kant's account, what is the decisive defect of an act of truth-telling performed only from fear of divine punishment?

- A. It rests on a factual belief about the afterlife that cannot be established by any argument that theoretical reason is competent to run.
- B. It cannot be universalised, since a maxim of truth-telling motivated by fear would be self-contradictory when made a law of nature.
- C. It treats the person deceived merely as a means, and therefore violates the requirement that humanity always also be treated as an end.
- D. It is heteronomous: the law is received from another will and made conditional on a desired outcome, so the act lacks moral worth.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Kant is not objecting to the belief's epistemic credentials here; he objects to the structure of the motivation whatever the belief's status.
- **B:** Incorrect: the maxim of truth-telling universalises perfectly well; it is the *motive*, not the maxim's form, that Kant is assessing in this example.
- **C:** Incorrect: the humanity formula concerns how others are treated, whereas the defect in this case concerns the ground on which the agent acts.
- **D:** Correct: obligation received from another will and made conditional on reward or fear is heteronomous, and heteronomy is what deprives the act of moral worth.

Examiner trap 10: The example is often reported as Kant objecting to religion; he is objecting to *sanction as a motive*, and the difference is the whole content of the point.

MCQ 11. Where God enters Kant's practical philosophy

What role do God, freedom and immortality play in Kant's moral philosophy?

- A. They are the three premises from which the categorical imperative is derived by an argument of practical reason.
- B. They are the objects of a revelation which practical reason may accept on authority once it has exhausted its own resources.
- C. They are practical postulates: what reason must presuppose for the moral outlook to be coherent, and not the source of the moral law itself.
- D. They are theoretical conclusions established by the arguments of the *Critique of Pure Reason* and then applied to moral questions.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the categorical imperative is derived from the form of rational willing, and nothing about God enters the derivation as a premise.
- **B:** Incorrect: nothing is accepted on authority here; the postulates are demands of practical reason and are not items of revealed content.
- **C:** Correct: they are presuppositions of the moral outlook, which is why Kant relates religion to morality without making God the ground of obligation.
- **D:** Incorrect: the first *Critique* denies precisely that theoretical reason can establish these, which is why they are postulated practically instead.

Examiner trap 11: "Kant removes God from morality" is a half-truth that loses marks; what is removed is God's role as the *ground* of obligation, and the postulates remain.

MCQ 12. The mediating claim

Which sentence best captures why natural law occupies the middle ground between divine command theory and Kantian autonomy?

- A. It grounds obligation in consequences while retaining the vocabulary of divine purpose, so it satisfies the theist without incurring metaphysical commitments.
- B. It denies that morality has any objective ground, and treats religious and secular moral languages as two equally serviceable ways of speaking.
- C. It makes revelation the sole source of moral knowledge while conceding that God's commands are constrained by his own nature.
- D. God grounds the objective order of human goods, but practical reason knows much of that order without any appeal to revelation.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: natural law is not consequentialist; basic goods are ends disclosed to practical reason, not outcomes to be maximised.
- **B:** Incorrect: natural law is strongly objectivist about the order of goods, and the description offered here is a relativism it explicitly rejects.
- **C:** Incorrect: the position's distinctive claim is precisely that much of the moral order is accessible *without* revelation, which this option reverses.
- **D:** Correct: God supplies the objectivity of the order and reason supplies the access, which is exactly what makes the position mediate between the two rivals.

Examiner trap 12: Collapsing natural law into divine command theory is the standard error; the discriminator is order-versus-decree and reason-versus-revelation, and one sentence fixes it.

MCQ 13. The objection natural law must answer

What is the standard objection to natural law, and what is the standard reply?

- A. Objection: it makes God superfluous. Reply: divine reason is required to explain why the order of goods is objective rather than a human construction.
- B. Objection: it derives a norm from a fact about human nature. Reply: practical reason grasps goods *as reasons*, so the starting point is already normative in itself.
- C. Objection: it cannot explain moral disagreement. Reply: disagreement is explained by the varying degrees of participation in the eternal law across cultures.
- D. Objection: it is too demanding. Reply: the theory grades obligations by vocation, so no agent is required to pursue every basic good simultaneously.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this reverses the direction of the standard complaint, which is that nature-to-norm inference fails, not that the divine grounding is idle.
- **B:** Correct: the naturalistic-fallacy worry is the standing objection, and the goods-as-reasons reply denies that anything normative is being derived from a bare description.
- **C:** Incorrect: moral disagreement is a general problem for every objectivist theory and is not the objection specifically pressed against natural law.
- **D:** Incorrect: demandingness is the standard complaint against utilitarianism; graded vows belong to the Jain structure, not to natural law.

Examiner trap 13: Naming an objection without its reply reads as a checklist; naming the reply and then conceding that it is defensible rather than decisive reads as evaluation.

MCQ 14. Matching the secular families to their bills

Which pairing of a secular grounding with its standing objection is correct?

- A. Virtue ethics - the perfect defector who is never detected has been given no reason at all to keep the agreement he has made.
- B. Utilitarianism - it presupposes a thick account of human nature which a sceptic is entitled simply to decline to share with the theorist.
- C. Contractarianism - the disposition-argument works only where dispositions are detectable, so the masked knave is unanswered.
- D. Humanism - it can override individual rights whenever aggregate welfare is thereby increased, and it may demand more than agents can give.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the undetected defector is the contractarian's difficulty; the virtue theorist's problem is the thickness of the nature his account presupposes.
- **B:** Incorrect: the thick-nature objection belongs to eudaimonism; utilitarianism's standing problems are rights-override and demandingness.
- **C:** Correct: constrained maximisation shows that being disposed to keep agreements maximises utility only where the disposition can be recognised by others.
- **D:** Incorrect: rights-override and demandingness are utilitarian bills; the humanist's difficulty is explaining the source of the worth of persons.

Examiner trap 14: Writing "secular ethics" as one lump concedes the field to the theist; naming two families and their distinct bills is the cheapest available upgrade on this stem.

MCQ 15. What the interaction view can and cannot claim

Which statement correctly describes the limits of the interaction view?

- A. Religion's mechanisms - exemplars, ritual, community, hope and worldview - really do shape conduct, and the same mechanisms can sanction exclusion.
- B. Because religion demonstrably improves conduct on average, religious moral claims acquire a presumption of truth that critics must rebut with evidence.
- C. Since influence runs in both directions, neither religion nor morality can be criticised from the standpoint of the other without circularity.
- D. The interaction view is a sociological thesis and therefore carries no philosophical content that a philosophy answer could legitimately use.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the symmetry is what makes the account evidential rather than promotional - the influence is real, contingent and available in both moral directions.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the correlation trap in its most seductive form, since a presumption of truth cannot be generated by a fact about behaviour.
- **C:** Incorrect: mutual influence does not preclude criticism; the prophetic tradition shows morality criticising religion from inside the tradition itself.
- **D:** Incorrect: the view carries the substantive philosophical claim that the relation is contingent rather than constitutive, which is exactly what dependence theses deny.

Examiner trap 15: The 2023 stem asks for influence *and* the interactive relation; answering only the first half caps an otherwise competent script, so allocate a paragraph to each.

MCQ 16. Testing a claimed command

Which set correctly lists the tests to which a claimed religious command remains answerable?

- A. Antiquity, consensus, textual attestation, institutional endorsement, ritual centrality and continuity of practice within the tradition.
- B. Identification, interpretation, consistency, proportionality, human dignity and the moral status of the authority invoked.
- C. Verifiability, falsifiability, publicity, repeatability, predictive success and coherence with established scientific results.
- D. Sincerity of the claimant, intensity of conviction, willingness to sacrifice, communal acceptance, historical fruitfulness and doctrinal orthodoxy.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: these are marks of traditional authority, and the whole point of the six tests is that traditional standing does not exempt a claim from moral assessment.
- **B:** Correct: these six are the tests any claimed command must pass, and they are applied within traditions by reformers as much as they are applied from outside.
- **C:** Incorrect: these are criteria from the philosophy of science and belong to the religious-language and verification debates, not to moral criticism of a command.
- **D:** Incorrect: sincerity and intensity are psychological facts about the claimant; they bear on culpability rather than on whether the command may be acted upon.

Examiner trap 16: State explicitly that these tests are applied *within and across* traditions; presenting moral criticism of religion as inherently secular is both inaccurate and rhetorically weaker.

MCQ 17. What dharma contains

Why can *dharma* not simply be translated as "morality"?

- A. Because it refers exclusively to ritual obligation, and the moral content attributed to it by modern writers is a nineteenth-century reconstruction.
- B. Because it is a purely soteriological concept concerned with liberation, and questions of conduct between persons fall entirely outside it.
- C. Because it joins normative order together with social role, ritual duty and soteriological consequence, all of which fall inside the concept.
- D. Because it names the impersonal causal law linking action to result, and therefore describes a mechanism rather than prescribing anything at all.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: ritual duty is one strand of the concept but not the whole of it, and the moral strand is present in the classical sources rather than imported later.
- **B:** Incorrect: this describes liberation-doctrine alone and omits the normative, social and ritual strands that make *dharma* the wide concept it is.
- **C:** Correct: the four strands are why *dharma* is not identical with universal morality, and why internal moral criticism of role-*dharma* is necessary rather than optional.
- **D:** Incorrect: this describes karma as a causal linkage, which is a related but distinct concept, and it drops the prescriptive force *dharma* plainly carries.

Examiner trap 17: Praising *dharma* as a superior fusion of the moral and the religious, without stating that role and ritual duty fall inside it, invites the reply that the concept sacralises hierarchy.

MCQ 18. Śāntideva's argument, not his name

Which reconstruction states Śāntideva's argument for impartial altruism in the *Bodhicaryāvatāra*?

- A. There is no substantial self; suffering is therefore ownerless, and the reason to relieve another's suffering exactly equals the reason to relieve one's own.
- B. All beings desire happiness and avoid suffering; therefore each has an equal claim; therefore an impartial distribution of goods is required of every rational agent.
- C. Compassion is commanded by the Buddha as the supreme virtue; therefore an adherent who fails to cultivate it has violated the central injunction of the path.
- D. Suffering is caused by craving; therefore craving must be extinguished; therefore concern for others is a skilful means towards the extinction of one's own craving.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the three-step derivation - no substantial self, ownerless suffering, symmetrical reasons - which grounds impartiality on a metaphysical rather than a theological premise.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is a generic impartialist argument from equal desire, available to any utilitarian, and it makes no use of the no-self premise that carries the weight.
- **C:** Incorrect: this converts the argument into an appeal to authority, which is exactly what the derivation avoids and what makes it valuable in this clause.
- **D:** Incorrect: this makes concern for others instrumental to one's own liberation, which inverts the argument's conclusion that the boundary between self and other is conventional.

Examiner trap 18: Citing Śāntideva by name without the three steps earns nothing; the examiner is checking whether the candidate possesses the argument or only the reference.

MCQ 19. The sharpest counterexample to the commander requirement

Why is Mīmāṃsā the most damaging of the Indian counterexamples to the claim that obligation requires a divine commander?

- A. Because it denies the authority of scripture altogether and derives duty from the observed consequences of action for social welfare.
- B. Because it treats moral rules as useful conventions that a community adopts and may revise whenever circumstances make revision advantageous.
- C. Because it retains full scriptural authority while grounding duty in injunction alone - authority without any personal commander.
- D. Because it grounds duty in the compassion of an impersonal absolute which functions as a commander in all but name and title.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this reverses the school's central commitment, since duty is known from injunction and precisely not from a calculation of consequences.
- **B:** Incorrect: conventionalism is the opposite of the position; injunction is binding independently of any community's adoption or revision of it.
- **C:** Correct: it concedes the theist his preferred kind of ground - scriptural authority - and still removes the personal legislator, which is why it is the strongest counterexample.
- **D:** Incorrect: this smuggles a commander back in under another description, which is exactly the move the counterexample is designed to block.

Examiner trap 19: Do not call the Indian non-theistic groundings "secular"; they are religious ethics without a divine commander, and the misdescription is visible and costly.

MCQ 20. Handling the 2025 obligation stem

The printed stem asks whether normative principles must bear reference to God in order to produce a feeling of obligation. What is the strongest way to structure the answer?

- A. Argue that the feeling of obligation is a psychological state, so the question belongs to moral psychology and cannot be settled philosophically at all.
- B. Split the stem into its grounding and motivational readings, refute the first by counterexample, and grant the second as one route among several.
- C. Establish that God exists, since only then can the question of what divine reference contributes to obligation be sensibly raised in the first place.
- D. Show that every historical morality has in fact had religious origins, so that reference to God is necessary in the only sense the stem could intend.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the stem asserts a necessary condition, which is a philosophical claim, and retreating to psychology declines the question rather than answering it.
- **B:** Correct: the wording straddles grounding and motivation, so splitting it and answering each half is what earns the top band on this stem.
- **C:** Incorrect: the question is about the grounding role of God-reference, not about God's existence, and the detour answers a different paper.
- **D:** Incorrect: this substitutes a genealogical claim for the necessity claim and is in any case defeated by ancient non-theistic groundings.

Examiner trap 20: A necessity claim is refuted by one working counterexample; producing four and then conceding the motivational point is a far stronger script than producing a survey of views.

MCQ 21. Why the asymmetry is not a matter of degree

The slogan says one can have morality without religion but not religion without morality. What explains the asymmetry?

- A. Religion is historically older than moral reflection, so the moral content of a tradition is always a later addition to an existing religious structure.
- B. Religious institutions are empirically more effective at producing moral behaviour than secular institutions of comparable size and resources.
- C. Moral philosophers have generally been religious, so the two fields are historically entangled in a way that makes separation artificial.
- D. Morality is *constitutive* of what qualifies as a religion, whereas religion is at most *supportive* of morality, and the two relations differ in kind entirely.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a claim about historical sequence cannot explain a conceptual asymmetry, and the priority asserted is in any case not established.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is a comparative behavioural claim, and even if true it would establish a difference of degree rather than the difference in kind at issue.
- **C:** Incorrect: biographical entanglement of philosophers is irrelevant to whether one concept is constitutive of the other.
- **D:** Correct: remove the moral claim and a system no longer answers to the concept of religion; remove religion and morality loses a resource, not a foundation.

Examiner trap 21: In "religion without morality" always split the normatively adequate reading from the descriptively identifiable institution, or the answer must either deny visible facts or abandon the asymmetry.

MCQ 22. The classical statement Hume could not answer

Which figure observes moral rules generally but makes exceptions when breaking them is both profitable and undetected, and is conceded by his own author to be hard to answer?

- A. Glaucon's just man of the *Republic*, who is stripped of reputation in order to test whether justice is chosen for its own sake.
- B. Hume's sensible knave of the second *Enquiry*, answered only by an appeal to the inward peace of mind and integrity he forfeits.
- C. Kierkegaard's knight of faith, who suspends the ethical in obedience to a command he cannot make intelligible to any other person.
- D. Aristotle's incontinent agent, who knows what is right and fails to do it because appetite overcomes the judgement of practical reason.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: Glaucon's just man is the *victim* of the thought-experiment rather than the exploiter of it; the exploiter there is the possessor of the ring.
- **B:** Correct: the sensible knave of *Enquiry* IX.ii makes profitable undetected exceptions, and Hume openly concedes the difficulty before retreating to inward peace of mind.
- **C:** Incorrect: the knight of faith suspends the ethical for a religious telos, not for profit, and his problem is unintelligibility rather than concealment.
- **D:** Incorrect: the incontinent agent fails through weakness of will and is not exploiting undetectability as a rational strategy at all.

Examiner trap 22: Reporting Hume as having answered the knave is a factual error; recording his own admission of difficulty is both accurate and, in an "examine" question, better rewarded.

MCQ 23. What karma adds to the "all the time" question

Why is karma the strongest religious answer to the demand for a reason to be moral in the undetected case?

- A. Because it promises a proportionate reward in a future life, so the agent's self-interest is aligned with moral conduct on a longer time-scale.
- B. Because it is enforced by a supervising deity whose knowledge is complete, so concealment from other human beings is of no assistance at all.
- C. Because it makes moral obligation conditional on membership of a community whose continuing approval the agent cannot afford to lose.
- D. Because it is exhaustive and impersonal - no unobserved act, no bribable judge - so invisibility to other persons is irrelevant.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the prudential reading the tradition itself criticises, and the *Gītā*'s renunciation of the fruit at 2.47 and 3.19 is directed precisely against it.
- **B:** Incorrect: several schools operate karma without any supervising deity, and it is the *absence* of a personal judge that makes the answer distinctive here.
- **C:** Incorrect: this converts karma into social sanction, which is the very mechanism the Ring of Gyges defeats by removing detectability.
- **D:** Correct: exhaustiveness and impersonality together remove the special status of the undetected case, which is what Gyges' challenge depends on.

Examiner trap 23: Presenting karma as cosmic bookkeeping invites the reply that it is Gyges with a bigger ring; cite *Gītā* 2.47 to show that the developed doctrine removes the fruit from deliberation.

MCQ 24. The verdict on the printed secular-ethics claim

What is the correct assessment of the claim that secular ethics cannot fully resolve why one should be moral all the time?

- A. Half true: secular ethics resolves the justificatory question, and the claim bites only on motivation in the undetected and costly case.
- B. Wholly true: without a transcendent sanction no reason of any kind can be given for acting morally when the act is costly and goes unobserved.
- C. Wholly false: contractarian theory answers the undetected case completely by showing that the disposition to keep agreements maximises expected utility.
- D. Unanswerable: since justification and motivation cannot be distinguished in practice, the claim has no determinate content to assess.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the justification-motivation distinction is the assessment, and religion's advantage in the hard case is scope, purchased at the price of heteronomy if it works by sanction.
- **B:** Incorrect: this overstates the claim, since Kantian, eudaimonist and Indian non-theistic groundings all supply reasons independent of transcendent sanction.
- **C:** Incorrect: constrained maximisation works only where dispositions are detectable, so the perfectly masked defector is precisely the case it does not reach.
- **D:** Incorrect: the distinction is drawn clearly in the literature and is exactly what makes the claim assessable rather than empty.

Examiner trap 24: Verdicts that summarise rather than decide sit in the "Strong" band and stop there; naming the concession that costs your own position something is what lifts a script to the top band.

REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

MCQ 25. The printed word, and the shape of the verdict

The 2018 stem asks about the inter-relatedness of "religiosity" and "immorality". Which handling is correct?

- A. Regularise the printed "immorality" to "morality", since the printed form is evidently a misprint and the intended question concerns moral conduct.
- B. Answer with a flat denial, on the ground that no religion teaches immorality and the association is therefore a category mistake.
- C. Answer with a flat affirmation, on the ground that religious history contains ample evidence of morally indefensible conduct by believers.
- D. Retain the printed word, treat religiosity as a disposition rather than as a system, and return a conditional verdict that names both of its conditions.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the held paper visibly prints "immorality", and silently regularising a printed term changes the question the examiner set.
- **B:** Incorrect: a flat denial ignores the ritual-substitution, boundary-marking, suspension and licensing routes that the traditions themselves document.
- **C:** Incorrect: a flat affirmation ignores the reformers, the internal-corruption reply and the comparison class of secular ideologies.
- **D:** Correct: the directive buys a conditional verdict, and the two conditions are whether the ultimate is itself moralised and whether the orientation is intrinsic or extrinsic.

Examiner trap 25: "Can one claim that there is an inter-relatedness between A and B?" never wants a yes or a no; it wants the conditions under which the relation holds, stated explicitly.

MCQ 26. Why "religiosity" correlates with nothing simple

Which analytical apparatus explains why measures of religiosity yield conflicting moral correlations?

- A. Allport's distinction between intrinsic religiosity and extrinsic religiosity, with Batson's later addition of the third quest orientation.
- B. Smart's seven dimensions of religion - doctrinal, mythic, ethical, ritual, experiential, social and material - applied as a scale of religious intensity.
- C. The distinction between substantive and functional definitions of religion, which determines in advance which traditions count as religions at all.
- D. Weber's typology of religious authority, which distinguishes charismatic, traditional and rational-legal sources of religious legitimacy.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: moral correlations differ sharply by orientation, which is exactly why religiosity as an undifferentiated variable correlates with nothing simple.
- **B:** Incorrect: the dimensional analysis answers the question what religion *is*, and it belongs to the Religion without God owner rather than to this stem.
- **C:** Incorrect: the definitional contrast decides which traditions count as religions and has no bearing on how individual religiosity relates to conduct.
- **D:** Incorrect: a typology of authority classifies sources of legitimacy and does not distinguish the orientations of individual religious commitment.

Examiner trap 26: Treating religiosity as one variable makes the conflicting evidence look like noise; naming the orientations converts the same evidence into the argument for conditional ambivalence.

MCQ 27. Answering an incompatibility stem

"Are religious beliefs and practices incompatible with moral behaviour?" What does the logical shape of this stem require?

- A. A balanced survey listing historical instances of religiously motivated benevolence alongside instances of religiously motivated harm.
- B. Identification of it as a necessity claim, refutation by a clear counter-case, then the weaker contingent claim that survives.
- C. A demonstration that religious belief is causally responsible for a measurable improvement in the moral behaviour of those who hold it.
- D. A definition of religion narrow enough to exclude any tradition whose practices could plausibly be described as morally objectionable.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a survey answers a comparative question, whereas an incompatibility claim is a necessity claim defeated by a single clear counter-case.
- **B:** Correct: refute the necessity claim, then state what survives - that the relation is contingent, since religion neither precludes nor guarantees moral behaviour.
- **C:** Incorrect: this overshoots, and the correlation trap applies: causal improvement is neither required to refute incompatibility nor sufficient to establish dependence.
- **D:** Incorrect: narrowing the definition to exclude counterexamples is question-begging and would in any case make the answer unfalsifiable.

Examiner trap 27: After refuting incompatibility, resist the temptation to conclude that religion guarantees moral behaviour; compatible is not guaranteed, and overshooting undoes the credit already earned.

MCQ 28. Where the divine-command argument for violence fails

The argument runs: whatever God commands is obligatory; God has commanded this act; therefore the act is obligatory. What is the correct assessment?

- A. Formally valid but unsound, failing at the second premise, since no fallible agent possesses the infallible identification that it requires.
- B. Formally invalid, because a conclusion about a particular act cannot be derived from a general premise about divine commands.
- C. Sound but morally irrelevant, because obligations generated by divine command apply only within the community that recognises the command.
- D. Unassessable, because premises concerning divine commands lie wholly outside the scope of philosophical evaluation altogether.

Answer: A.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: conceding validity and locating the false premise is the required move, and Kierkegaard's admission that Abraham cannot make himself intelligible confirms that no public case is available.
- **B:** Incorrect: the inference is a straightforward instantiation and is plainly valid; calling it invalid misdescribes the argument and forfeits the analysis.
- **C:** Incorrect: calling it sound concedes the conclusion, and community-relativity is a different objection that does not touch the premise at issue.

- **D:** Incorrect: the printed question asks precisely whether such an argument can support the conclusion, so declining to assess it declines the question.

Examiner trap 28: Answering the religious-violence stem with a list of conflicts answers a historical question; state each candidate in premises and show which premise fails.

MCQ 29. The decisive refutation of coercion for salvation

Which argument decisively refutes the claim that coercion can be a benefit because it produces conformity leading to salvation?

- A. That the harms of coercion are always disproportionate to any spiritual benefit that could conceivably be secured by it in the long run.
- B. That salvation is a private matter, so the state has no legitimate interest in the religious conformity of its subjects.
- C. That belief is not directly voluntary, so force compels outward profession and yields hypocrisy rather than salvation.
- D. That no religious tradition has ever in fact endorsed the use of coercion in matters of belief and religious practice at all.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: a proportionality argument concedes that the mechanism could work and merely prices it, which is weaker than showing the premise is false.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is a political argument about jurisdiction, and it leaves the paternalist's premise about the efficacy of coercion untouched.
- **C:** Correct: this is Locke's refutation in *A Letter Concerning Toleration* (1689) - the understanding cannot be compelled by outward force - and it makes the second premise false.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is historically false, since Augustine's use of *compelle intrare* in the Donatist controversy is the standard counter-instance to be examined.

Examiner trap 29: Augustine's *compelle intrare* must be presented as a historical position examined, never as an endorsement; mishandling it is a factual error and a tonal one at once.

MCQ 30. What every restraint-regime also contains

When comparing just war, the classical Islamic juristic tradition and *dharma-yuddha*, which qualification is required for an honest answer?

- A. That the three converge so completely on authority, cause, intention, discrimination and proportionality that no significant divergence remains between them.
- B. That only the Western tradition developed a systematic body of doctrine, the other two consisting of scattered exhortations without juristic form.
- C. That the constraints are revelation-dependent in each case, and therefore unavailable to anyone outside the tradition that formulates them.
- D. That each contains an internal realist counter-tradition relaxing the constraints under necessity, such as Kauṭilya's *kūṭa-yuddha* in India.

Answer: D.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: divergences remain, notably on temporal and spatial limits, and asserting complete convergence flatters all three traditions rather than comparing them.
- **B:** Incorrect: all three possess long juristic or śāstric literatures, and the claim is both inaccurate and precisely the kind of adjudication the handling rule forbids.
- **C:** Incorrect: the convergence of three independent traditions is evidence that the constraints are rationally derivable rather than revelation-dependent.

- **D:** Correct: naming the internal counter-currents is what makes the comparison honest and supports the verdict that no tradition has solved the problem of necessity.

Examiner trap 30: Never assert the greater/lesser *jihād* distinction as canonical or treat *dār al-islām/dār al-ḥarb* as Qur'ānic; cite contested items with their flag or leave them out.

MCQ 31. The limit of the genealogical method

Why does Nietzsche's genealogy of morality not by itself refute the morality it describes?

- A. Because his historical reconstruction of the slave revolt has been shown by later scholarship to be inaccurate in most of its particulars.
- B. Because he never applies the method to his own valuations, and a method that exempts its author cannot be used against anyone.
- C. Because origin does not settle validity, so his target must be the *value* that a valuation expresses rather than its truth-value.
- D. Because a genealogy is a descriptive enterprise, and no descriptive enterprise can ever bear on a normative question in any way whatever.

Answer: C.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the objection at issue is logical rather than historiographical, and it would apply even if every historical detail were correct.
- **B:** Incorrect: the self-application worry is a real difficulty but it is not the standard genetic-fallacy objection that this question is asking about.
- **C:** Correct: this states the objection and the reply together - asking what kind of life a valuation expresses and produces is a legitimate, distinct question.
- **D:** Incorrect: this overstates the fact-value gap and would rule out the genealogical enterprise entirely rather than locating its actual limit.

Examiner trap 31: Cite Scheler's *Ressentiment* (1912) as the named counter-authority - Christian love descending from abundance rather than impotence - instead of asserting in your own voice that the genealogy is a caricature.

MCQ 32. What lifts a script to the top band

According to the graded verdict ladder for this clause, what distinguishes a top-band answer from a strong one?

- A. A longer treatment of divine command theory, with the four-step argument set out in full and each presupposition separately defended.
- B. A discriminating distinction, such as justification versus motivation, together with a concession that costs the writer's own position something.
- C. A greater number of thinkers named, so that the examiner can see the breadth of the candidate's reading across both Western and Indian sources.
- D. A more emphatic conclusion, stated in the first person and repeated at the close of every paragraph so that the position is unmistakable.

Answer: B.

Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: additional exposition of a single theory adds length without adding discrimination, and length is not what separates the two bands.
- **B:** Correct: the ladder specifies exactly this - a discriminating distinction plus a costly concession - and the strong band's typical fault is a verdict that summarises rather than decides.
- **C:** Incorrect: naming more thinkers without argument is what the ladder describes as asserting rather than arguing a non-theistic grounding.

- **D:** Incorrect: emphasis is not decision; a decided verdict names what would change it, which is a matter of content rather than of tone.

Examiner trap 32: The single most reliable top-band marker in this clause is a concession that damages your own conclusion; write it deliberately rather than hoping it emerges.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Verified previous-year questions - 11 complete solutions

Word bands used throughout. 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words. Every question below is reproduced in its **exact printed wording** from the audited Philosophy of Religion previous-year ledger, 2018-2025, in which this clause owns eleven question-parts - the largest single ownership in the section, including three distinct demands in 2019. **The model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

Timing skeleton. 10 marks - 1 minute to decode, 1 to outline, 6 to write, 1 to check. 15 marks - 1 / 2 / 10 / 2. 20 marks - 2 / 3 / 13 / 2. **Standing penalties in this clause:** merging the four dependence claims; inferring logical dependence from sociological influence; giving one horn of the Euthyphro; identifying *dharma* with universal morality; answering the violence stem with a list of conflicts; and using the sentence commonly paraphrased as "without God everything is permitted" as a verified quotation from Dostoevsky.

PYQ 1 - 2018, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can one claim that there is an inter-relatedness between 'religiosity' and 'immorality'? Discuss.

- The held paper visibly prints "**immorality**"; it is retained here rather than silently regularised to "morality".

Demand decoding: "Can one claim that there is an inter-relatedness between A and B?" buys a **conditional** verdict with the condition named. The subject is *religiosity* - a disposition - not *religion*, the system. Neither a flat yes nor a flat no scores.

Model solution: Yes, but conditionally. Religiosity is a disposition, not a system, and the question is whether being religious is systematically bound up with moral failure.

Four routes suggest it can be. Observance may displace moral substance - the danger named by the Hebrew prophets against sacrifice without justice, by the Buddha against ineffective Vedic sacrifice, by Kabīr and Nānak against ritualism, and by the *Gītā* (2.42-43) against those enchanted by flowery words of ritual reward. That every tradition contains this critique is itself the evidence. Religiosity also binds by marking a boundary, with a predictable cost toward outsiders; it can license the suspension of ordinary ethics, which Kierkegaard states honestly; and it produces both scrupulosity and moral licensing.

Against a systematic connection: the same traditions generate reformers and exemplars; the immoral religionist is judged by the tradition's own norms, so this is internal corruption; and secular ideologies have produced comparable failures, so religiosity is not the differentiating variable.

Allport's intrinsic and extrinsic orientations, with Batson's quest, explain why religiosity as such correlates with nothing simple.

Religiosity is therefore an amplifier: it magnifies the moral content of the religion and the motive of the agent. The relation is real but conditional on whether the ultimate is itself moralised and whether the orientation is intrinsic.

Why this earns marks:

- Opens by fixing the subject as the disposition, which is what the stem actually names.
- Uses internal critiques as evidence, so the case for the connection is drawn from the traditions rather than against them.
- Deploys the intrinsic / extrinsic / quest apparatus, which is the only thing that explains conflicting correlations.
- Supplies the comparison class, which most scripts omit.
- Closes with a conditional verdict and names both conditions, which is exactly what the directive buys.

Upgrade route for this answer: the compressible part is the four-route list - at 150 words, keep ritual substitution and boundary-marking with their named evidence, and reduce suspension and licensing to a single clause. What must never be cut is the pair of conditions in the final sentence, because the directive is grading the conditionality rather than the catalogue.

PYQ 2 - 2019, Q5(c), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can there be a philosophical argument to support violence in the name of religion? Discuss.

Demand decoding: The stem asks about the **structure of justification**, not the history of conflict. State candidate arguments in premises and locate the failing premise. Assess arguments; name no contemporary community.

Model solution: No sound argument survives, though several are formally valid - which is why the work lies at the premises.

The divine-command argument runs: whatever God commands is obligatory; God has commanded this; therefore the act is obligatory whatever its moral appearance. It is valid and fails at the second premise, which demands an infallible identification of the divine will no fallible agent possesses. Kierkegaard concedes the point: Abraham cannot make himself intelligible, and an argument unavailable for public assessment cannot justify anything to anyone.

The defence-of-the-sacred argument conflates supreme *value* with *vulnerability*: persons may be defended by force because they can be harmed, whereas the sacred, on most theologies, cannot be diminished by an insult.

Soteriological paternalism claims coercion produces conformity leading to salvation. Locke's *A Letter Concerning Toleration* (1689) refutes the premise: the understanding cannot be compelled by outward force, so coercion yields hypocrisy. Augustine's *compelle intrare* is the historical counter-position, examined not endorsed.

Cosmic dualism fails by demonising persons, which the image of God, the Buddha-nature, the self in all beings and non-injury all deny. The identity-honour argument is not religious at all.

Euthyphro, epistemic fallibility and Gandhi's means-end unity generalise the point. Only ordinary defensive force survives, and it is not religious. Religion's contribution here is restraint, not licence.

Why this earns marks:

- Concedes formal validity before denying soundness, which demonstrates philosophical competence rather than moral disapproval.
- Names the failing premise in every case instead of gesturing at implausibility.
- Uses Locke as the decisive refutation and handles Augustine correctly as an examined position.
- Disqualifies the identity argument as non-religious, which is a discrimination few scripts make.
- Ends with the restraint-not-licence formula, which is the clause's signature verdict.

Upgrade route for this answer: under time pressure, compress arguments two and four into a single sentence each - "value is not vulnerability" and "total demonisation contradicts every major religious anthropology" - and protect the Locke paragraph, since the falsity of the coercion premise is the one refutation that is decisive rather than merely strong.

PYQ 3 - 2019, Q5(d), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Does a devoted commitment to a religious way of life make man go astray from social morality? Examine.

Demand decoding: "Examine" a causal or normative tendency claim. Distinguish the disposition from the system, name the routes by which the tendency could operate, and block each.

Model solution: Not systematically, though four routes make the worry intelligible.

Withdrawal is the first: renunciation appears to remove the agent from ordinary social duty. But withdrawal in most traditions is a reordering of obligation rather than its abandonment, and the renouncer is typically bound by stricter rules, not looser ones.

Suspension is the second, and the strongest: if religious duty can override ethics, commitment supplies a route to acts that are ethically indefensible. Kierkegaard's teleological suspension states this honestly - and states its own limit, since the agent cannot make himself intelligible and therefore cannot justify himself publicly.

Boundary-marking is the third: intense commitment can displace impartial duty by loyalty to an in-group. Allport's distinction locates this precisely in *extrinsic* religiosity, where religion serves status and belonging, rather than in commitment as such.

Substitution is the fourth: observance replaces justice. Every tradition names and condemns this in its own prophetic literature.

The correlation is therefore with orientation, not with depth of commitment; and intense intrinsic commitment characteristically produces reformers, ascetics and exemplars.

Devoted commitment does not lead away from social morality. It intensifies whatever the tradition's moral content and the agent's orientation already are.

Why this earns marks:

- Treats the stem as a tendency claim and answers it by naming conditions rather than by asserting a verdict.
- Uses Kierkegaard as both the strongest statement of the worry and its own limitation.
- Locates the boundary problem in orientation, which keeps the answer analytic rather than apologetic.
- Distinguishes intensity of commitment from direction of commitment, which is the discrimination the stem rewards.

Upgrade route for this answer: the four routes are the structure and must survive compression; what can go is the second sentence of each block. If only two can be kept, keep suspension - because it is the only route that a defender of religion concedes - and boundary-marking, because the intrinsic/extrinsic apparatus does the analytic work.

PYQ 4 - 2019, Q7(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Secular ethics cannot fully resolve as to why one should be moral all the time. Examine.

Demand decoding: The weight is on "all the time" - the undetected, costly, unreciprocated act. Fidelity to that scope is what is being marked. Separate justification from motivation.

Model solution: The claim is half true, and the half that is true is motivational rather than logical.

The hard case is classical. Glaucon's Ring of Gyges (*Republic* II 359d-360b) asks whether justice survives invisibility; Hobbes's Foole holds covenant-breaking rational when it pays; Hume's sensible knave (*Enquiry* IX.ii) makes profitable undetected exceptions, and Hume concedes he finds the knave hard to answer, retreating to the inward peace of mind the knave forfeits. Bradley (*Ethical Studies*, Essay II) and Prichard (1912) press the further point that demanding a non-moral reason to be moral may be a malformed request.

Each secular answer stops at the same place. Kant shows the imperative is categorical, not conditional - but explains why the law binds, not why this agent will obey it. Gauthier's constrained maximisation shows that the disposition to keep agreements maximises utility - where dispositions are detectable; the perfectly masked knave survives. Eudaimonism makes morality constitutive of flourishing - presupposing a thick nature the sceptic may decline. Sympathy and reciprocity explain a motive, and reciprocity has an explicit exception clause for the undetected case.

Religion's answers differ in scope. Divine sanction abolishes the undetected case, at the cost of heteronomy. Divine love escapes that cost. Karma is stronger still: exhaustive and impersonal, with no unobserved act and no bribable judge, so Gyges' ring has no purchase; and *niṣkāma-karma* (*Gītā* 2.47, 3.19) dissolves the question by removing the fruit from deliberation.

So: secular ethics resolves the justificatory question as well as any theory can. The printed claim bites only on motivation in the hard case, where religion's advantage is scope - purchased, if it works through sanction, at the price of moral worth.

Why this earns marks:

- Builds the entire answer on the operative phrase rather than on the general question.
- Gives four secular answers with four distinct stopping points, not one lump.
- Reports Hume's own admission accurately instead of manufacturing a resolution.
- Gives the theist the strong versions - love and *niṣkāma-karma* - rather than only sanction.
- Concludes by distinguishing justification from motivation, and prices the religious advantage.

Upgrade route for this answer: if the clock forces a cut, drop Bradley and Prichard to a half-sentence and keep all four secular stopping points, because the marker is checking whether each theory is answered *at the undetected case*. Never compress the final paragraph: the justification-motivation split is the assessment, and an answer that omits it has described the debate instead of examining the claim.

PYQ 5 - 2020, Q8(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Are religious beliefs and practices incompatible with moral behaviour? Discuss.

Demand decoding: Incompatibility is a **necessity** claim, and a necessity claim falls to one clear counter-case. Refute it, then state the weaker true claim that survives.

Model solution: They are not incompatible, and a necessity claim of this kind is defeated by a single clear counter-case.

The case for incompatibility is not frivolous. Religious practice can substitute observance for justice; sacred authority can immunise a command from ordinary moral assessment, which Kierkegaard's teleological suspension states in its strongest form; boundary-marking imposes a predictable cost toward outsiders; and moral licensing lets observance stand in for conduct.

Each of these, however, is condemned from inside the traditions. The prophetic literature denounces sacrifice offered without justice; the Buddha criticises ineffective ritual; Kabīr and Nānak attack ritualism and caste-observance; the *Gītā* (2.42-43) disparages those enchanted by promises of ritual reward. Reform movements against caste and *satī* are moral criticism conducted in religious vocabulary. Jain non-injury and Buddhist compassion are moral commitments generated by religious doctrine rather than despite it. Any one of these defeats incompatibility.

The correct diagnosis of the failures is *internal corruption*, not counter-example: if morality is partly constitutive of worthy religion, a religion sanctioning injustice has failed by its own standard, as a corrupt court fails by the standard of law rather than refuting law.

What survives refutation is the weaker and true claim: the relation is **contingent**. The same mechanisms - exemplars, ritual, community, hope, worldview - can support care or sanction exclusion, and the operative variable is orientation and moral content rather than religiosity itself.

Religious beliefs and practices are compatible with moral behaviour, and do not guarantee it.

Why this earns marks:

- Identifies the logical shape of the claim and answers it in the appropriate way.
- States the case for incompatibility at full strength before defeating it.
- Uses internal critique, which cannot be met with the charge of imposing alien standards.
- Distinguishes internal corruption from counter-example with a precise analogy.
- Refuses to overshoot: compatible is not guaranteed, and the answer says so.

Upgrade route for this answer: the compressible block is the list of internal critiques - two named instances suffice where four are given. What must be protected is the closing distinction, since the commonest way to lose marks after a successful refutation is to conclude that religion therefore *produces* moral behaviour.

PYQ 6 - 2021, Q6(c), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Do you consider that religion and morality are inseparable? Give reasons for your answer.

Demand decoding: A first-person verdict with **ranked reasons**. Separability must be shown by an actual working system, not merely asserted.

Model solution: I do not consider them inseparable, and the reasons rank in this order.

First and strongest: obligation has in fact been grounded without any theistic premise, repeatedly and independently. Mīmāṃsā grounds duty in injunction alone - a pure deontology with scriptural authority and no commander who is a person, which concedes the theist his preferred kind of ground and still removes the legislator. Śāntideva's argument in the *Bodhicaryāvatāra* VIII derives impartial altruism from a metaphysical premise: with no substantial self, suffering is ownerless, so the reason to relieve another's suffering is exactly as strong as the reason to relieve one's own. Jain ethics grades obligation through the lesser and greater vows around non-injury. Kant grounds obligation in rational self-legislation, with God, freedom and immortality as postulates rather than as the source of the law.

Second: the Euthyphro blocks the reduction of morality to divine command. If goodness is constituted by the command, morality is arbitrary and "God is good" becomes a tautology; if the command follows goodness, goodness is independent. The modified theory grounds commands in a loving nature, which blocks arbitrariness but concedes that "loving" is a moral concept we already possess.

Third, and conceding to the other side: the relation is nevertheless close. Religion motivates and sustains moral commitment through exemplars, ritual, community, hope and a sustaining worldview, and morality reciprocally criticises and reforms religion.

Fourth: the asymmetry is real but explains itself. Morality is *constitutive* of what qualifies as a religion; religion is only *supportive* of morality.

They are therefore distinguishable in grounding, interactive in history and motivation, and mutually critical in normative practice - which is a close relation, and not inseparability.

Why this earns marks:

- Obeys "give reasons" by ranking them explicitly rather than listing them.
- Demonstrates separability with working systems rather than asserting it.
- Includes a reason that concedes ground to the opposite view, which the top band requires.
- Explains the asymmetry instead of merely noting it.
- Returns a first-person verdict in the exact form the directive requested.

Upgrade route for this answer: the ranking is the architecture and must survive; if space runs short, give reason one with two systems rather than four, keeping Mīmāṃsā - because it is the counterexample that concedes most - and Śāntideva, because it is an argument rather than an example.

PYQ 7 - 2022, Q5(b), 10 marks

Exact verified question: "One can have morality without religion but not religion without morality." Discuss.

Demand decoding: A quotation stem asking for the **asymmetry** analysed. Test each direction separately, then explain why the asymmetry holds.

Model solution: The asymmetry holds, but for a reason the slogan hides.

Morality without religion is possible, and demonstrated. Kant grounds obligation in rational autonomy; utilitarianism in welfare; humanism in dignity. Mīmāṃsā grounds duty in injunction with no personal commander, and Śāntideva grounds impartial altruism in the ownerlessness of suffering. These are working systems, several of them ancient.

Religion without morality requires a distinction. A *descriptively identifiable* religious institution can plainly transmit immoral commands or practices, and calling it immoral does not make it sociologically nonexistent. But a *normatively adequate* religion without morality is very hard to defend, because every religion makes claims about worthy life, duty, transformation or liberation - an ethic is internal to the concept.

The Euthyphro reinforces the first direction by blocking strong divine command theory, while the interaction view preserves what is true on the other side: religion motivates and sustains moral life.

The explanation of the asymmetry is that morality is *constitutive* of what we are willing to call a religion, whereas religion is at most *supportive* of morality - and constitutive and supportive relations are not two degrees of one relation.

Why this earns marks:

- Tests the two directions separately, as a quotation stem requires.
- Splits the second direction into its descriptive and normative readings.
- Explains the asymmetry rather than merely endorsing the slogan.
- Uses named non-theistic systems rather than the word "secular ethics".

Upgrade route for this answer: at 150 words the four named systems in paragraph two reduce to two. The sentence that must be written in full is the constitutive/supportive contrast, because it is the only part of the answer that gives a *reason* for the asymmetry rather than restating it.

PYQ 8 - 2023, Q5(c), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Does religion influence the moral behaviour? Explain the interactive relation between religion and morality.

Demand decoding: **Two deliverables**, marked separately: the influence, and the interaction model. Causal influence must not be allowed to slide into logical dependence.

Model solution: Religion does influence moral behaviour, through five identifiable mechanisms. Narrative exemplars supply models of a life worth imitating; ritual repetition forms habit and disposition; community supplies visibility, belonging and sanction; hope and repentance make failure survivable and effort renewable; and a religious worldview makes sustained moral effort intelligible rather than absurd. A vow of non-violence strengthened by religious discipline is the canonical case: the strengthening is real, while the vow's moral defensibility still requires reasons accessible beyond the community.

The influence is contingent in both directions. The same mechanisms can sanction exclusion - exemplars can be partisan, ritual can substitute for substance, community sanction can police a boundary.

The relation is therefore interactive, not one-way. Morality acts on religion in turn: conscience criticises religious practice, as in the prophetic denunciation of ritual without justice and in reform movements against caste and *saṭi*, and a religion is judged by its ethical fruits. A claimed command remains answerable to identification, interpretation, consistency, proportionality, human dignity and the standing of the authority invoked.

Causal influence, however well attested, establishes neither logical dependence nor moral truth.

Why this earns marks:

- Delivers both halves of the printed stem, in separate paragraphs.
- Names five mechanisms rather than asserting influence in general.
- States the contingency symmetrically, which keeps the account evidential.

- Closes on the wall between causal influence and logical dependence, which is the clause's governing control.

Upgrade route for this answer: if time is short, give three mechanisms rather than five and keep the whole of the second half, since the interaction model is the deliverable most frequently omitted and is separately marked.

PYQ 9 - 2024, Q5(a), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Can there be a religion without morality? Discuss.

Demand decoding: The single direction that the 2022 slogan asserts. The answer stands or falls on the descriptive/normative split.

Model solution: Descriptively yes, normatively no - and the distinction is the answer.

A descriptively identifiable religious institution can transmit immoral commands or practices. Calling such an institution immoral does not make it sociologically nonexistent, and pretending otherwise requires denying visible facts.

A *normatively adequate* religion without morality, however, is very hard to defend. Every religion makes claims about worthy life, duty, transformation or liberation; an ethic is therefore internal to the concept rather than appended to it. The constraint is functional, not stipulative: a system asserting nothing whatever about how one ought to live could not orient a life, prescribe a path or specify what transformation consists in - and so could not perform the work by which religion is identified in the first place.

The hardest case is a heavily ritual tradition whose ethical demand looks minimal. But even there the ethical content is thin and contested rather than absent: rules about who may perform what, when, and in what disposition are themselves normative claims about a worthy life.

The traditions confirm this from within. The prophetic denunciation of sacrifice without justice, the Buddha's criticism of ineffective ritual, and the *Gītā*'s disparagement of those enchanted by ritual reward (2.42-43) are all internal insinuations that religion without ethics has failed by its own standard.

Why this earns marks:

- Answers in the first line with the distinction the question turns on.
- Explains why the constraint is functional rather than a matter of definition, which pre-empts the "merely verbal" objection.
- Meets the hardest counterexample instead of avoiding it.
- Grounds the normative claim in the traditions' own self-criticism.

Upgrade route for this answer: the paragraph on the hardest case is the first candidate for compression to a single sentence. The functional-not-stipulative sentence must be kept, because without it the answer is exposed to the charge that it has merely defined religion so as to guarantee the result.

PYQ 10 - 2025, Q5(c), 10 marks

Exact verified question: Present an account of Nietzsche's criticism of religion and morality.

Demand decoding: Both objects and their connection. The stem couples religion with morality, so the link between the diagnosis and the genealogy is itself part of what is marked. This clause is the primary owner of this question.

Model solution: Nietzsche's critique has two inseparable halves.

The first is a diagnosis. "God is dead" (*The Gay Science* Section 125) is not an atheological argument but a cultural claim: the Christian-metaphysical framework has become unbelievable to the very culture built on it, and that culture has not yet grasped the consequences (Section 108, Section 343).

The second follows from the first: the morality that framework carried is now unsupported, and the *Genealogy of Morality* (1887) asks where it came from. The first essay derives good/evil from the inversion of an aristocratic good/bad by the slave revolt, in which *ressentiment* becomes creative; the decisive point is that slave morality is *reactive*, saying No to an outside first. The second derives guilt (*Schuld*) from debt (*Schulden*), with cruelty turned inward producing the bad conscience and religion positing an infinite creditor. The third shows the ascetic ideal prevailing because it gave suffering a meaning - "rather will nothingness than not will" - and ends in the irony that the will to truth destroys the belief in God. *Beyond Good and Evil* calls Christianity "Platonism for the people"; *The Antichrist* attacks pity as life-denying.

Positively: revaluation, will to power, the Übermensch, eternal recurrence, *amor fati*. Nihilism is the interim, not the goal.

The critique faces the genetic-fallacy charge - origin does not settle validity - met by replying that his target is the *value* of a valuation; and Scheler's *Ressentiment* (1912) answers that Christian love descends from abundance, not impotence. His achievement is to make morality itself an object of suspicion; his failure is that the revaluation supplies no criterion for preferring one creation of values to another.

Why this earns marks:

- Supplies both objects and states the link between them explicitly, which is what the coupling in the stem is testing.
- Reads Section 125 correctly as a cultural diagnosis rather than an argument against God's existence.
- Gives all three essays with their distinct derivations rather than a general impression of the *Genealogy*.
- Names Scheler as the counter-authority instead of asserting the caricature charge in its own voice.
- Ends on the durable-critique / failed-programme verdict.

Upgrade route for this answer: the positive programme compresses to one line without loss. What cannot be compressed is the transition sentence between the two halves - an answer that presents the diagnosis and the genealogy as two topics rather than one argument has missed the specific demand created by the word "and" in the printed stem.

PYQ 11 - 2025, Q8(b), 15 marks

Exact verified question: Is it necessary for the normative principles to bear reference to God in order to produce a feeling of obligation in a moral agent? Critically discuss.

Demand decoding: A **necessity** claim, tested. The wording straddles grounding and motivation - "bear reference to God" is grounding-shaped, "produce a feeling of obligation" is motivational - so the highest-scoring move is to split it and answer both.

Model solution: No, and the stem repays being split, since its wording straddles two different claims.

Read as a claim about **grounding** - that reference to God is what makes a principle binding - it is refuted by counterexample, and a necessity claim falls to one. Kant grounds obligation in rational self-legislation: a law given by another will is heteronomous and destroys the unconditional character of obligation, so a commanded morality is not a stronger foundation but a defective one; God, freedom and immortality remain as practical postulates rather than as the source of the law. Mīmāṃsā is sharper, because it concedes more: duty is grounded in injunction alone, retaining full scriptural authority while removing any commander who is a person. Śāntideva derives impartial altruism from the ownerlessness of suffering. Jain ethics grades obligation through vows around non-injury.

Divine command theory's own difficulty confirms the result. The Euthyphro forces a choice between arbitrariness - on which "God is good" collapses into a tautology - and the independence of goodness. Adams blocks the first horn by grounding commands in an essentially loving nature, and Alston denies the regress by treating God as the supreme standard; but calling that nature "loving" deploys a moral concept we must already grasp, so non-arbitrariness is bought by conceding conceptual independence.

Read as a claim about the **feeling** of obligation, the necessity also fails: duty, character, solidarity, compassion and self-respect all produce the felt bind. What is true is weaker - God-reference is one effective route, and for many agents a powerful one.

That concession must be priced. Motivation supplied by sanction is heteronomous and forfeits moral worth; only the divine-love version escapes the charge. God-reference may therefore strengthen motivation without constituting obligation.

Why this earns marks:

- Identifies the claim as a necessity claim and splits its two readings, which is the specific demand created by the printed wording.
- Produces four independent counterexamples and explains why Mīmāṃsā is the most damaging.
- Gives the modified theory its due before stating the residue, so the treatment is evaluative rather than dismissive.
- Concedes the motivational point and then prices it, which is the top-band move on this stem.

Upgrade route for this answer: the modified-theory paragraph is the compressible one, reducible to Adams plus the residual objection in two sentences. The split between the two readings must never be compressed away, because it is the only thing in the answer that responds to the exact phrase "produce a feeling of obligation".

Original solved Mains practice - 6 models

These are original questions written in the printed styles of this clause. They are **learner practice, not previous-year questions**.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: "The Euthyphro dilemma refutes divine command theory but leaves theistic ethics standing." Discuss.

Model answer: The claim is correct, and stating why requires care about what the dilemma targets.

The Euthyphro (10a) asks whether the pious is loved because it is pious or pious because it is loved. On the first horn, command constitutes goodness - so cruelty would have been good had it been commanded, and "God is good" collapses into "God commands what God commands". On the second, the command tracks a goodness it does not create, and the constitutive thesis is abandoned.

That is a refutation of a theory of *grounding*, not of theism. A theist may occupy the second horn deliberately: natural law does exactly this, grounding an objective order of human goods in divine reason while allowing practical reason to know much of it without revelation. Modified divine command theory takes the other route, grounding commands in an

essentially loving nature, which blocks arbitrariness at the cost of conceding that "loving" is a moral concept we already grasp.

The dilemma therefore removes one theistic ethics and leaves at least two others intact.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: Does the fact that religion motivates moral conduct show anything about the grounding of moral obligation? Examine.

Model answer: It shows nothing about grounding, and the reason is structural rather than empirical.

Religion's motivational contribution is real and identifiable: narrative exemplars, ritual formation, community sanction, hope and repentance, and a worldview in which sustained moral effort is intelligible. Behavioural evidence of religious influence on conduct is therefore unsurprising.

But grounding, knowledge, motivation and sanction are four separable relations. Grounding asks what constitutes the validity of an obligation; motivation asks what supplies the operative reason to comply. A cause of compliance is not a constituent of obligation, and success in one column proves nothing in another.

The point is sharpened by a canonical case: a vow of non-violence may be strengthened by religious discipline while its moral defensibility still requires reasons accessible beyond the community. The strengthening is genuine; the justification is elsewhere.

Two further controls follow. Influence is contingent - the same mechanisms can sanction exclusion. And correlation may itself require controls for community, selection and orientation.

Religion may therefore be motivationally indispensable to a particular agent and grounding-irrelevant at the same time.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: "Karma answers the question that secular ethics leaves open, but at a cost of its own." Critically discuss.

Model answer: The claim is largely right about the answer and right to insist on the cost.

The open question is the undetected, costly, unreciprocated act - Glaucon's Ring of Gyges, Hobbes's Foole, Hume's sensible knave, whom Hume concedes he cannot fully answer. Every secular reply stops at the same place. Kant explains why the law binds, not why this agent will obey it. Gauthier's constrained maximisation needs dispositions to be detectable. Eudaimonism needs a thick nature the sceptic may decline. Reciprocity has an explicit exception clause for exactly the undetected case.

Karma closes that gap in a way no theistic sanction does as cleanly. It is exhaustive - there is no unobserved act - and impersonal - there is no judge to petition or deceive. The Ring of Gyges presupposes that invisibility to persons matters; where the moral order is coextensive with the causal order, it does not. The *Gītā* strengthens the position further: *niṣkāma-karma* (2.47, 3.19) removes the fruit of action from deliberation, so the prudential question is not merely answered but dissolved.

The costs are two. The first is unverifiability, which is the standing objection to this grounding as arbitrariness is to divine command and formalism to Kant. The second, if karma is presented as cosmic bookkeeping, is that it becomes prudence on a larger scale - Gyges with a bigger ring. The tradition's own answer to the second cost is *niṣkāma-karma*, which is why the citation matters rather than decorates.

A control must accompany any use of the doctrine: karma motivates the agent's own accountability and licenses no observer's inference of guilt from another's suffering.

Karma therefore answers the motivational question with a reach no secular theory matches, and pays for it in verifiability rather than in moral worth - which is a better bargain than divine sanction makes.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: Assess the claim that moral criticism of religious practice is necessarily an external, secular imposition.

Model answer: The claim is false, and the evidence that refutes it comes from inside the traditions.

Moral criticism of religion is standardly internal. The Hebrew prophets denounce festivals and sacrifices offered without justice; the Buddha criticises Vedic sacrifice as ineffective; Kabīr and Nānak attack ritualism and caste-observance; the *Gītā* (2.42-43) disparages those enchanted by promises of ritual reward. Reform movements

against caste and *satī* argued in religious vocabulary, appealing to non-harm, equality, conscience and spiritual unity. The structural point is more important than the examples. Interpretation of a claimed command already deploys moral concepts: identifying which reading is faithful, which authority is legitimate, and which application is proportionate cannot be done without them. The six tests to which any claimed command remains answerable - identification, interpretation, consistency, proportionality, human dignity and the moral status of the authority invoked - are therefore not imported after the fact. They are already operating inside the interpretive act.

This answers the standing objection that morality judging revelation is arrogance, the finite judging the infinite. What is being judged is a human claim about a command, not the divine as such.

Two qualifications are owed. First, religious moralities conflict with one another over duties, authority, exceptions and interpretation, so internal criticism does not converge on a single moral code. Second, the reply that an immoral religious practice is *internal corruption* rather than a counter-example works only if morality is genuinely treated as constitutive of worthy religion - which is a substantive commitment, not a rhetorical escape.

Moral criticism of religion is therefore neither necessarily secular nor necessarily hostile. It is most powerful precisely where it is internal, because there it cannot be met by the charge of imposing alien standards.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: "Religion supplies morality with motivation and scope; morality supplies religion with a standard. Neither supplies the other with a foundation." Critically evaluate.

Model answer: The thesis is defensible in all three of its parts, and evaluating it requires separating grounding from everything else.

Neither supplies a foundation - the first half. Morality is not conceptually grounded in religion. The Euthyphro forces the choice between arbitrariness, on which "God is good" is a tautology, and independence, on which goodness is prior to command. Modified divine command theory blocks the first horn by grounding commands in an essentially loving nature, and Alston denies the regress by treating God as the supreme standard; but describing that nature as loving uses a moral concept we must already possess, so non-arbitrariness is bought with conceptual independence. Four independent non-theistic groundings confirm the result empirically: Kantian self-legislation; Mīmāṃsā's duty from injunction alone, which retains scriptural authority while removing any personal commander; Śāntideva's derivation of impartial altruism from the ownerlessness of suffering; and the Jain vow-structure around non-injury.

Neither supplies a foundation - the second half. Religion is not grounded in morality either. A religion is more than an ethic: it makes claims about ultimate reality, transformation and liberation, and reducing it to morality misdescribes it as thoroughly as reducing morality to command misdescribes morality.

Religion supplies motivation and scope. The mechanisms are identifiable - exemplars, ritual formation, community sanction, hope and repentance, a sustaining worldview - and the scope claim is strongest in the hard case. Where secular theories stop at the undetected, costly act, karma is exhaustive and impersonal, so invisibility to persons is irrelevant, and *niṣkāma-karma* (2.47, 3.19) removes the fruit from deliberation entirely.

Morality supplies a standard. Conscience criticises religious practice, and does so most powerfully from within: prophetic denunciation of ritual without justice, and reform against caste and *satī*. A claimed command remains answerable to identification, interpretation, consistency, proportionality, human dignity and the standing of the authority invoked.

The qualifications that decide the grade. The motivational advantage is priced: if it operates through sanction it is heteronomous and forfeits moral worth, so only the divine-love and *niṣkāma-karma* versions win it cleanly. The influence is contingent: the same mechanisms can sanction exclusion. And the asymmetry the thesis implies needs its own explanation - morality is *constitutive* of what qualifies as a religion, while religion is only *supportive* of morality.

Verdict, and the defeater. The thesis is correct: the relation is one of motivation, scope and mutual criticism, not of foundation in either direction. What would change this verdict is a demonstration that some obligation cannot be grounded without a theistic premise - and the four non-theistic groundings are precisely the evidence that no such demonstration is available.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: "Religion's distinctive contribution to the ethics of force is restraint, not licence." Examine this claim with reference to the arguments for religious violence and to the comparison of normative war traditions.

Model answer: The claim is sound, and both halves of it require separate demonstration: that religion supplies no licence, and that it does supply restraint.

No licence - the arguments, in premises. The divine-command argument is formally valid: whatever God commands is obligatory; God has commanded this; therefore it is obligatory. It fails at the second premise, which requires an infallible identification of the divine will no fallible agent possesses. Kierkegaard's teleological suspension concedes exactly this - Abraham cannot make himself intelligible - so no public justification is available, and a justification that cannot be assessed by others is not a justification to others. The defence-of-the-sacred argument conflates supreme *value* with *vulnerability*: persons may be defended by force because they can be harmed, whereas the sacred, on most theologies, cannot be diminished by an insult. Soteriological paternalism fails because its second premise is false: Locke's *A Letter Concerning Toleration* (1689) shows that the understanding cannot be compelled by outward force, so coercion produces hypocrisy, not salvation - Augustine's *compelle intrare* being the historical counter-position, examined and not endorsed. Cosmic dualism fails by demonising persons, which the image of God, the Buddha-nature, the self in all beings and non-injury all deny. The identity-honour argument is not a religious argument at all, but a group-identity claim in religious vocabulary.

The general rebuttals. The Euthyphro: if the act is wrong, calling it commanded does not make it right. Epistemic fallibility: revelation-claims are contested inside traditions, so the required certainty is unavailable. Gandhi's means-end unity: the means is the seed of the end, so a sacred end cannot sanctify an unholy means. And every tradition contains its own resources against violence.

Restraint - the comparison. Aquinas (ST II-II q.40) requires legitimate authority, just cause and right intention, and Walzer (1977) systematises discrimination and proportionality. The classical Islamic juristic tradition treats armed struggle under *qitāl*, hedged by authority, just cause, non-combatant immunity, protection of crops and trees, and the honouring of treaties. *Dharma-yuddha*, in the *Mahābhārata*'s *Śānti*- and *Anuśāsana-parvans* and the *Dharmaśāstra*, requires the graded means *sāma*, *dāna*, *bheda*, *danḍa* before force and protects the sleeping, unarmed, fleeing, surrendering and wounded, ceasing at sunset and forbidding poisoned weapons.

The philosophical yield. Three traditions with different scriptures converge on authority, cause, intention, discrimination and proportionality. That convergence is evidence that the constraints are rationally derivable rather than revelation-dependent, which cuts against any claim to a special religious licence and for the claim of culturally embedded restraint.

The qualifications. Each tradition contains a realist counter-current - *raison d'état*, contested modern readings, and Kauṭilya's *kūṭa-yuddha*. Contested items must be flagged, not asserted: the greater/lesser *jihād* report is disputed among ḥadīth scholars, and *dār al-islām/dār al-ḥarb* are juristic constructions rather than Qur'ānic terms. No community is to be characterised and no faith adjudicated.

Verdict, and the defeater. Only the ordinary permission of defensive force survives, and it is equally available to a secular ethic - so religion adds no licence, while it does add restraint stricter than secular law requires. What would change this verdict is a religious argument that is valid *and* whose premises are publicly establishable; none of the five candidates meets the second condition, and the epistemic obstacle to the strongest of them is principled rather than accidental.

Question-shaped timed-paper compression plan

Compression in this clause is not uniform shortening. Each printed demand has one element that must survive at any length and one that is safe to lose first.

Printed demand	Protect at all costs	Cut first
Inter-relatedness of religiosity and immorality (2018)	the two named conditions in the verdict	two of the four routes
Philosophical argument for violence (2019 Q5(c))	the Locke refutation and the "valid but unsound" framing	arguments two and four, reduced to one sentence each

Printed demand	Protect at all costs	Cut first
Devoted commitment and social morality (2019 Q5(d))	the four routes as a structure	the second sentence of each route
Secular ethics and "all the time" (2019 Q7(b))	the justification-motivation split	Bradley and Prichard, reduced to a clause
Incompatibility (2020)	the closing "compatible is not guaranteed"	two of the four internal critiques
Inseparability (2021)	the ranking of reasons	two of the four non-theistic systems
The asymmetry quotation (2022)	the constitutive/supportive contrast	two named secular systems
Influence and interaction (2023)	the entire second deliverable	two of the five mechanisms
Religion without morality (2024)	"functional, not stipulative"	the hardest-case paragraph
Nietzsche (2025 Q5(c))	the transition linking diagnosis to genealogy	the positive programme, reduced to one line
Reference to God and obligation (2025 Q8(b))	the split between the two readings	the modified-theory paragraph

Self-scoring and next steps

Band	Diagnostics correct	What to do next
Below 18 / 32	-	Re-read Sessions 1-7 and redo items 1-14; the failure is almost always the four-relation distinction
18-23 / 32	-	Redo items 15-24 after Sessions 8-15; the gap is Indian grounding and the "all the time" problem
24-28 / 32	-	Work the remedial set 25-32 and write PYQ 4, 6 and 11 to time
29+ / 32	-	Write Original 5 and 6 to time; the remaining gain is verdict discipline, not content

Trap census. Thirty-two unique examiner traps are attached to the diagnostics, and fifteen owner-level traps are assembled in Session 21. The five that recur most often across the eleven printed questions are: merging the four dependence relations; inferring dependence from correlation; giving one horn of the Euthyphro; answering the violence stem historically; and returning a verdict that summarises rather than decides.

Independence note

Every model answer in this package is independent learner practice constructed from the repository's owner files and the audited previous-year ledger. None is an official UPSC key, and no marks awarded by the Commission are known for any of these questions.